

SANTISHREE DHULIPUDI PANDIT

JNU is Addictive, Students Don't Want to Leave

JNU HAPPENED BY MISTAKE. This was the 1980s and Hindi professor Namvar Singh, a close friend of my father, had come to visit us in Madras. He was the one who suggested to my father that I should apply in JNU. I had just completed my masters and was keen on pursuing a PhD in international relations. Prof. Singh sent me the application forms which I duly filled out and submitted. I was called for the interview and coming to Delhi was such an eye opener. I had never been to the capital before and everything here was different. A little known fact is that when I came here I did not know even a word of Hindi. But I picked it up soon enough.

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I was in JNU from 1985 to 1990 and completed my MPhil and PhD here. At the time, the campus was heavily polarised towards the Left but I never once felt unsafe or experienced any sort of ragging. It was a wonderful experience with people from all over the country coming in, brilliant professors and a diverse library collection. The atmosphere here was something I will never forget.

Today, I would like to say the atmosphere still remains largely the same. However, the polarisation aspect has waned. I wouldn't say it has gone completely. It still exists but we are trying to find healthier ways to debate, present arguments and overcome differences. While there is some polarisation, I still find JNU to be a highly inclusive university where students help one another greatly. This was the same during my time, a strong sense of community and inclusiveness regardless of where you came from.

And, of course, the number of students we have on campus has increased significantly. Infrastructure-wise, we have a lot more facilities today—such as hotels, library, schools of studies, messes—but the quality has deteriorated over the years due to poor maintenance. It is something we are working to fix as soon as possible.

In my time, we had some excellent professors to mentor us in our research work. Mine was K.P. Misra, an expert on diplomacy and non-alignment who was frequently consulted by the then prime minister, Indira Gandhi. He taught me so much about discipline, hard work and how to write research papers. Coming from a state university, many students like me didn't have good research writing skills, so an MPhil helped us learn the basics of great research work and writing. Today, we no longer offer an MPhil degree but professors still help students learn the basics. JNU is mainly a research university and we still encourage various types of study. Another thing that has remained the same is a commitment towards inter-disciplinary work and the encouragement of critical thinking.

Overall, JNU remains as addictive as it was in my time. After awhile, students do not want to leave at all. Campus life is completely different to the outside world. Students get so many facilities for an incredibly nominal cost. There are always activities and learning opportunities. With Left politics shrinking, and the safety and infrastructural improvements, the university remains the best place to pursue the social sciences in India. ■

*(as told to **Sonali Acharjee**)*

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